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VIII. Whatsoever thou dost affect, whatsoever thou dost project, so do, and so project all, as one who, for aught thou knowest, may at this very present depart out of this life. And as for death, if there be any gods, it is no grievous thing to leave the society of men. The gods will do thee no hurt, thou mayest be sure. But if it be so that there be no gods, or that they take no care of the world, why should I desire to live in a world void of gods, and of all divine providence? But gods there be certainly, and they take care for the world; and as for those things which be truly evil, as vice and. wick-edness, such things they have put in a man s own power, that he might avoid them if he would: and had there been anything besides that had been truly bad and evil, they would have had a care of that also, that a man might have avoided it. But why

Explain this passage

Simple meaning

Marcus Aurelius reflects on morality, mortality, and the nature of the universe. First, quoting Theophrastus, he argues that acting wrongly out of pleasure (lust) is worse than acting wrongly out of anger, because anger often stems from a perceived injury, whereas lust is a deliberate surrender to self-indulgence. Second, he urges the reader to live each moment as if it were their last. He reasons that if

the gods exist, they are good and will not harm us, and if they do not exist or care, life in a purposeless universe is hardly worth clinging to anyway; therefore, one should trust divine order. He adds that external circumstances like wealth, poverty, life, and death happen equally to good and bad people, meaning they are morally neutral ('neither good nor bad'). Finally, he advises looking past worldly illusions, recognizing that material things quickly decay and human opinions are fleeting.

Difficult vocabulary

Theophrastus — An ancient Greek philosopher and successor to Aristotle as head of the Peripatetic school.

vulgar — Common, ordinary, or popular, rather than philosophical or precise.

bewray — To reveal, betray, or show evidence of.

impotent — Lacking self-restraint, weak in will, or powerless.

affect — To aim at, desire, or set one's mind upon.

project — To plan, design, or set forth an intention.

promiscuously — Indiscriminately, randomly, or without distinction.

Author's intent

The author intends to steel himself—and by extension the reader—against the fear of death, the temptation of pleasure, and the anxiety caused by external hardships. Explicitly, he presents rational arguments for Stoic acceptance of fate: sorting moral faults by severity, affirming divine providence, and reducing worldly anxieties to indifference toward externals. A reasonable interpretation is that Marcus is writing these notes to himself as psychological self-discipline, constantly reinforcing Stoic dogmas to maintain emotional stability while burdened with imperial duties.

Reasoning

- Main claim 1: Sins committed out of pleasure are worse than those committed out of anger, because the angry person acts from a place of perceived hurt, whereas the lustful person chooses pleasure unprovoked.
- Main claim 2: Death and external events are not to be feared; either the gods govern well, or the universe lacks divine care, but in neither case should a rational person panic.
- Supporting reason: The gods have placed true evil (vice) entirely within human control to avoid, implying that external things (wealth, poverty, life, death) are indifferent because they cannot make

a person morally better or worse.

- Conclusion: Because external conditions happen equally to the good and the bad, they are fundamentally neutral and should not dictate our peace of mind.

Historical context

The passage reflects classical Stoic philosophy, which flourished in the Hellenistic and Roman periods. Stoics like Marcus Aurelius believed in a rational, divinely ordered universe (logos) and taught that virtue is the only true good, while externals like wealth, health, and social status are indifferent.

Connection to the book

In the broader context of Book Two, this passage continues Marcus's urgent reminders to focus entirely on the present moment and internal moral integrity. It builds on earlier warnings against wasting time and being distracted by external opinions by explicitly classifying life, death, and worldly goods as indifferent.

Evidence from the passage

> those sins are greater which are committed through lust, than those which are committed through anger.

Shows the psychological grading of moral faults, distinguishing calculated self-indulgence from reactive emotional defense.

> As for life therefore, and death, honour and dishonour, labour and pleasure, riches and poverty, all these things happen unto men indeed, both good and bad, equally; but as things which of themselves are neither good nor bad

Establishes the core Stoic doctrine of 'indifferents' (adiaphora), arguing that worldly outcomes do not correlate with moral worth.

Uncertainty

The text relies heavily on the translation of 16th-century scholar Meric Casaubon, whose rendering of archaic English can occasionally obscure the precise nuance of the original Greek. Additionally, Marcus is addressing himself privately, leaving some transitions between disparate thoughts (such as jumping from Theophrastus to the existence of the gods) abrupt.